



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
STANFORD GSB

FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

ABOUT THE SCHOOL

"The majority of people who go to GSB do extraordinary things in ordinary jobs." Stanford's MBA Program is the most selective in the world. It has maintained the highest ratio of applicants to available seats of any business school in the U.S. for the last decade. It has also had the lowest acceptance rates of any major business school in the world. Accepting only 6% of those who apply for admission yield is over 93%. No school is more choosy than Stanford.

The Stanford MBA class size is less than half the size of Harvard. And with Silicon Valley in its back yard a growing number of tech and engineering applicants are choosing the GSB over their East coast rival. The small class size lends itself to an intimate and close-knit community environment and pretty much guarantees that almost every student knows each other. Its motto is "Change Lives Change Organizations Change the World."

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

As you might expect from one of the world's top business schools Stanford's MBA program is known for its strengths across many areas in particular entrepreneurship innovation finance technology general management and social enterprise.

MBA CLASS OF 2020

Number of Applicants: 7,342	MBA Class Size: 419
Admissions Selectivity: 6.1%	Yield: 93.56%
Total Tuition: \$149,412	

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 33%; Consulting 18%; Technology 24%; Starting Own Business 15%
Top employers include: McKinsey, Google, Stanford, Cisco, Bain, BCG, Microsoft, Apple
Avg. Base Salary: \$144,455 Employment in 3 months: 95%

MBA RANKINGS	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	5	-	4	-	4	7	2	5	1	1
Financial Times	4	4	1	2	2	4	2	4	1	1
Forbes	-	2	-	1	-	1	-	2	-	2
The Economist	7	8	8	9	9	13	5	5	5	7
US News	1	1	1	1	1	1	2	4	4	2

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Work Exp.: 4.6 yrs	Avg. GMAT: 734	Avg. GPA: 3.7
Int'l Students: 42%	Female Students: 41%	

Deadlines for Sept 2019/20:	Round 1 – Sept. 15, 2020
	Round 2 – Jan. 6, 2021
	Round 3– Apr. 6, 2021

Sources: Stanford GSB, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

ESSAYS 2019-2020

Cites Stanford GSB on its website: In each essay, we want to hear your genuine voice. Think carefully about your values, passions, aims, and dreams prior to writing them.

1. What matters most to you, and why? 650 words (suggested)

For this essay, we would like you to:

- Do some deep self-examination, so you can genuinely illustrate who you are and how you came to be the person you are.
- Share the insights, experiences, and lessons that shaped your perspectives, rather than focusing merely on what you've done or accomplished.
- Write from the heart, and illustrate how a person, situation, or event has influenced you.
- Focus on the "why" rather than the "what."

2. Why Stanford? Describe your aspirations and how your Stanford GSB experience will help you realize them. 400 words (suggested)

- Explain your decision to pursue graduate education in management.
- Explain the distinctive opportunities you will pursue at Stanford.

Length: Your answers for both essay questions combined may not exceed 1,050 words. View also the GSB's formatting guidance.

Tips for Tackling Stanford GSB's Iconic 'What Matters Most' Essay

By Matt Symonds

Fortuna Co-Founder and Director Matt Symonds is the author of the international bestseller "Getting the MBA Admissions Edge," sponsored by Goldman Sachs, McKinsey & Co., BCG, and Bain & Co. As the founder of the World MBA Tour in 1995, he has an extensive business school network, regularly interviewing deans, faculty and admissions directors for the media, and his industry knowledge makes him a regular guest expert on TV, in the press, and at conferences. He covers business education for BusinessWeek, The Economist, Forbes, America Economia, Times of India and many other global publications.

Stanford GSB's notorious (call it iconic) essay endures after some 15 years: What matters most to you, and why? This elegant question epitomizes the sentiment 'simple but not easy.' It exacts the kind of profound self-awareness and fearless authenticity that can tie the most excellence-driven applicant into knots in the spirit of delivering something they hope is striking, clever and distinctive.

Taking the time to answer this question is an exercise that in and of itself holds a lot of value, reflects Fortuna's Tatiana Nemo, a Stanford GSB alum & former MBA admissions interviewer.

"This kind of perspective-taking helps unearth a clarity of purpose that's invaluable for anyone who's ever wrestled with the expectations of others, peer pressure and unexamined momentum," says Nemo. "If the question is tackled thoughtfully and bravely, with keen focus on the action of speaking from the heart rather than worrying on the effect that doing so will create, then it provides a substantial and valuable view into the applicant's character, motivations, fears and beliefs."



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

Essay tips, continued.

Fortuna's Heidi Hillis, Stanford GSB grad and former GSB Alumni Interviewer, has pushed many a successful candidate to dig deeper in the spirit of getting to the heart of the question, which is intrinsically connected to the school's tagline: Change lives. Change organizations. Change the world.

"It is so easy to get caught up in the day-to-day, to plow forward with life and career without really considering our values. It's a vital thing for everyone to do periodically, but especially early in your career," says Hillis. "It's a golden time to pause, get introspective, and make sure you're headed where you want to go – that you even know where you want to go and what success looks like for you. This essay question makes you stop and think about what it is that makes you who you are."

So why does Stanford ask this question, and why have they have stuck with it for so long? Stanford GSB Assistant Dean of MBA Admissions & Financial Aid, Kirsten Moss, spoke to what MBA Admissions really wants at the CentreCourt MBA Festival in San Francisco in 2017.

"One of the things that has been proven over and over in research is that highly inspirational leaders who get the highest level of performance from their organizations really know what drives them, and they are thinking beyond themselves to the problems they can make change and have an impact on. So in our application one of our key questions is 'what matters most and why?', and it has been an iconic question for a long time," says Moss. "Taking the time to understand what matters to you will be your true north as a leader, no matter what school you go to, in the rest of your life... You will be one step ahead of the game in terms of being able to motivate others."

So what matters most to you, and why? Start off with your gut or intuitive response. Jot this down – we'll come back to it later.

Stanford suggests aiming for 750 words, allowing no more than 1,150 words to cover this essay and a second essay question, "Why Stanford?" Maybe you feel that you can answer the first part of the question in one word, with things like love, family or chocolate. But the heart of the question, the part that reveals your life's calling and uniquely personal journey for getting there, requires deeper introspection. Why does that one thing matter more than any other?

If you're staring in terror at the blank page, Nemo advises: "Invest time building a timeline of the influences, instances, moments that have shaped you. Dig deep connecting the dots between what has shaped you and who you've become. Devote essay A to talk about past and present, and talk about the future in essay B. Both essays need to be coherent and could read as a single story."

Our team at Fortuna Admissions offer advice on how to best tackle the structure of this essay, while telling your 'story':

1. Start with identifying a person, event, or experience that greatly impacted you.
2. What morals, values, and lessons did you gain from this experience?
3. How do you use these morals, value, and lessons today, and how do they impact your drive, your motivation, and your vision of the world? (Remember, Stanford's aforementioned motto.)
4. How has the development of your career linked to the above?
5. Conclude by restating the link between your values and your career vision, and why these goals are important to you.



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

Essay tips, continued.

Questions to ask yourself:

- If you're still drawing a blank as to what really matters to you, start by noting down all of your experiences to date, and exploring things like:
- What was it like growing up? How did your parents/guardians and your surroundings shape you? Were you a happy child? What were you regularly involved in (by force or by choice)?
- What was school like? Were you focused? How did your friends influence you? What kind of people did you hang around with? How did you feel, emotionally as a teenager? What did you get involved with?
- What has your career been like? Are you happy with your choices? Any regrets? What do you like/dislike about your job and why?
- What extra-curricular activities and hobbies do you engage in and what's the reason behind them?
- What do you love or hate about life? What makes you happy or sad, frustrated or upset?
- What gets you up (or not get up) in the morning? In this life, what do you really, care about?

Now look at all of your answers – including what you initially wrote down as your gut response. Can you identify an underlying theme (or themes) throughout your life? Probably. You may amaze yourself that there's a method to the madness in your life! Consider soliciting family and friends for some anecdotes about you that may not be front of mind. Now, through telling a compelling story, highlight the key themes and connect them to the general ideas expressed in your essays.

Even though you may have to devote hours on this essay through brainstorming, research, talking with others, writing a draft, then another (and then another), just remember that it's all inside you. As my Fortuna colleague Sharon Joyce says, "There is no right story other than your own. And the person best poised to tell that story is you."

Dare to be vulnerable, honest and personal. "It is common to see answers like 'never giving up' or 'always to push myself beyond my comfort zone' – thematically that's okay, but make sure to go beyond. Give examples and tell stories that only you can tell," says Hillis. "Don't tell a story that you think the admissions committee wants to hear – your essay is not a marketing tool. It's ok – sometimes better – to share a failure story. Tell the story that defines who you are and how you came to be that way. Use details – colors, smells, feelings. Let the reader go away knowing something that they only could have learned in the essay."

Shouldn't we all really think about what matters most to us, whether we are applying to business school or not? Take this on as a personal challenge, not merely as an MBA essay question. Stanford wants to know what matters most to you, and so should you.



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

By Matt Symonds

Tip #1 - Defining change

There are not many institutions in the world that can get away with the tagline "Change lives. Change organizations. Change the world." But Stanford might be one of them. So when it comes to defining your career goals, you should bear in mind that the admissions office is seeking individuals who are looking to have real impact, whether professionally or in society. The selectivity of the business school means that they can look beyond students whose goal is to secure a place in a strategy consulting firm or investment bank, and identify those applicants who are driven by a desire not just to excel in their careers but also to help others and have a positive impact. So as you think about your own post-MBA career goals, include a longer-term view about the areas where you think you can affect real change. Whether that means using technology to transform an industry, creating a niche business in the world of finance or medicine, or influencing the agenda for social attitudes in a region of the world, such a vision will carry far more weight if you can point to activities and commitments from your past and present that underpin your passion and sense of purpose. The school considers that past actions are usually the best predictor of future behavior, so your application should reflect who you are through what you have done.

Tip #2 - Yield and the importance of fit

The admissions yield at Stanford GSB is second only to Harvard, which underlines the fact that the school is the top choice for many applicants. A yield above 80% also suggests that the GSB admissions team is very good at identifying those applicants who have a strong fit with the culture and values of the school. Stanford is a relatively small program of around 400 students, and is seeking to build a very close knit, supportive community. Successful applicants not only have academic pedigree, stellar GMAT scores and personal and professional accomplishments to their name. They also have integrity, the ability to open up, be vulnerable, and grow in a supportive yet challenging environment. As such, the Admissions office works very hard to bring together a group of students who are open, humble and have strong integrity and this provides the foundation of the level of camaraderie and trust that you find at the school. Does that sound like you? Then share your story with the school in a natural, genuine way.

Tip #3 - Career goals

Pretty much all of the leading business schools can all open the door to McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Goldman and Morgan Stanley. Only 19% of the Stanford Class of 2019 went in to consulting and 5 times as many secured a place in private equity or venture capital as investment banking. Many are starting a new business many of them in the technology sector. The school likes you to dream big while demonstrating that your goals and career vision are viable given your track record of achievement and excellence.

Tip #4 - Contributing to life on 'The Farm'

For a program that consistently ranks among the top 2 or 3 in business school rankings, the Stanford MBA does not need to hear from you how wonderful it is. The brand and reputation of the school speak for themselves. But you do need to show your passion and absolute commitment to the school. The admissions team wants to understand how you can contribute to the Stanford community, and how the education you receive will provide the knowledge and skills to make the difference in your career. A campus visit, attending an info session and reaching out to students and alumni are all opportunities to better familiarize yourself with the distinct personality of the school.



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

So take the time to research the many clubs and organizations available at both the business school and the wider Stanford University campus, 'The Farm', and think about how you can bring energy and engagement outside the MBA classroom. There is no perfect candidate, so be honest about the areas in which you can improve, and how you hope to make the most of your two years in Palo Alto.

Tip #5 - What matters most to you?

This notorious essay is at the heart of the MBA application to the Stanford GSB, and typically ties applicants in knots as they try to come up with an answer that they hope is clever, striking, or even profound. The school is looking not just for extremely bright and successful individuals, but also people who have strong values and want to have a positive impact in the world. Taking the time to really think about this question provides invaluable insight about your life purpose and values, and the true you that emerges from this introspection helps the GSB to evaluate fit and diversity of contribution to the class.

To best tackle the structure of this essay, start with identifying a person, event, or experience that greatly impacted you, and think about the morals, values, and lessons you gained from this experience or interaction. How do you use these lessons today, and how do they impact your drive, your motivation, and your vision of the world? Can you link them to the development of your career and the life choices you have made? You also need to make the connection between your values and your career vision, and why these goals are important to you. Even though you might have to spend hours on this essay through brainstorming, research, talking with others, writing a draft, then another (and then another), just remember that it's all inside you... it's your story, and you just have to find it and pull it out.

Tip #6 - Importance of recommenders

We cannot emphasize enough how important recommendations are at the GSB. Stanford may have reduced the number of recommendations required from three to two, but the endorsement of a third-party who has genuine insight into your work, what makes you tick, and how you compare to your peers can carry more weight than anything you share in your essays. The school would like to hear from your current direct supervisor who needs to provide detailed examples that support the assertions they are making. All too often a recommendation sounds too generalized, and though positive and supportive it could have been written about many young professionals rather than specifically about you. This is particularly true for letters that come from partners in a consulting firm or directors at an investment bank, who may have been asked on numerous occasions to write a reference for business school. The temptation is for them to use a template they have on their hard drive, and though undeniably efficient for them this will do you more harm than good. The school is already swamped with applications from these industries, so you need to make sure that they take the time to produce something thoughtful, enthusiastic, and personalized to you.

Tip #7 - Authenticity and humility

With 17 applications for each place in the MBA program at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, it is no surprise that candidates feel enormous pressure to stand out in the crowded applicant pool by producing impressive application essays and letters of recommendation for their admissions file.

But you can go too far in a bid to secure your place, and replace authenticity and self-confidence with boastfulness and arrogance. The Assistant Dean of MBA Admissions acknowledges that boastfulness can be an easy trap to fall into when candidates spend their



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR APPLYING TO STANFORD

time worrying how they compare to other applicants. But he states that personal humility is not inconsistent with professional ambition and professional drive. And humility is certainly one of the traits the GSB is looking for in its admits.

So while there are many approaches to creating a compelling application, there is clearly an appropriate tone to strike in your application. Rather than pumping up your accomplishments in the hope of impressing the admissions reader, or indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, MIT Sloan, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson, Yale SOM and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

